

Women in the Social, Political and Economic History of the Mongol Empire

Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan: Cases from the Yuan dianzhang. By BETTINE BIRGE (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2017; pp. 336. £46.95);

Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire. By ANNE BROADBRIDGE (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2018; pp. 362. £74.99).

The prominent role played by individual women in the political history of the Mongol Empire (1206–1388) has long garnered attention. Mongol queens (khatuns) in particular controlled vast herds and flocks, servants and slaves, as well as armies and the revenues necessary to support them. Medieval visitors to the Mongol Empire, such as Ibn Battuta and Marco Polo, remarked with astonishment on the ostentatious way that these women displayed their wealth and power at the khan's itinerant court (*ordu*). Mongol queens and princesses received foreign envoys, participated in the council of notables (*quriltai*), and in some instances served as regents and rulers of the empire; they were serious players in the factional politics that dominated the unified empire and each of the Mongolian successor states across Eurasia. Modern scholarship has sought to explain why these women enjoyed such power by situating them in the wider historical and anthropological context of the Inner Asian steppe. These studies have often been premised upon outdated ideas about the economic limitations of mobile pastoralism, which supposedly precluded the kind of androcentrism found in many of the agrarian core territories of Asia. The books reviewed here, however, present a more complex picture of the multiple social, environmental and political factors which unsettled gender relations in Mongol-ruled Eurasia and provided a small number of women with the power to shape the trajectory of the empire. The story they tell is one that more fully encapsulates the uneven experience of Mongol rule, both among Mongol women and those whom they ruled.

The approaches adopted by these authors are varied and target different groups of women within the Mongol Empire. This divergence of focus and methodology is, to some extent, a product of the markedly different source material each employs. Far more records have survived from East Asia, especially China, than from the ostensibly Arabic- and Persian-speaking Islamic world, which has led to a phenomenon humorously described by some scholars as 'source-envy'. The promulgation of block printing across China resulted

in the production and survival of many manuscripts, which have allowed researchers working on the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1271–1368) to provide a far more comprehensive analysis of the experience of women from all walks of life. Beginning with Paul Ratchnevsky, much work has been done on juridical handbooks and legal compendia to elucidate the treatment of women under Yuan law. Unlike their predecessors, the Yuan never promulgated their own law code, but rather maintained multiple legal systems for their Chinese, Mongol and Inner Asian subjects.¹ The resulting confusion led Chinese jurists to collect and publish cases to serve as precedents for future decisions. Bettine Birge has analysed a number of these compilations and has produced a translation of the section on marriage litigation from the *Yuan dianzhang* (*Statutes and Precedents of the Yuan Dynasty*), under the title *Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan*. The translation of the decisions and rulings pertaining to marriage builds upon her work of 2002, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction in Yuan and Sung China (960–1368)*, to explore the malleable and contested nature of conjugal law under Mongol rule.

Though lacking the kind of source material available to specialists on the Yuan, historians of the Ilkhanate (1258–1335) have likewise presented an increasingly complex picture of women at the Mongol *ordu*. These histories, building upon the seminal work of Shirin Bayani and a far shorter treatment by Ann K.S. Lambton, draw upon court chronicles and regional dynastic histories produced under the Ilkhanate to identify the contribution of Mongol queens to the political history of Iran. Both Bayani and Lambton situate the Mongols among the conquest dynasties which emerged from the steppe beginning in the eleventh-century and afforded significantly greater prominence to women than the earlier Iranian-Islamic dynasties.² Bayani explains that this contrast was in part due to the different lifeways of the nomadic Mongols and the sedentary Iranians. She posits that women enjoyed greater autonomy in the mobile pastoral economy of the steppe and that the number of powerful women in the Ilkhanate therefore declined with the settlement and Islamisation of the Mongols in Iran. This argument, though not without merit, has often been uncritically accepted by later historians without any clear justification. Recent works by Anne Broadbridge and Bruno De Nicola have expanded upon the work of Bayani by focusing upon individual institutions and relationships, not

1. P. Ratchnevsky, 'The Levirate in the Legislation of the Yuan Dynasty', in Tamura Hakushi Taikan Kinen Jigyōkai, ed., *Tamura Hakushi shōju Toyoshi ronso* [Asiatic Studies in Honor of Dr. Jitsuzō Tamura on the Occasion of his Sixty-Fourth Birthday] (Kyoto, 1968), pp. 45–62; P. Ratchnevsky, 'La condition de la femme mongole au 12^e/13^e siècle', in W. Heissig, J.R. Kruger, F.J. Oinas and E. Schütz, eds, *Tracta Altaica: Denis Sinor, sexagenario optime de rebus altaicis merito dedicate* (Wiesbaden, 1976), pp. 509–30.

2. S. Bayānī, *Zan dar Irān 'Asr-i Mughūl* (Tehran, 1974), pp. 9–32; A.K.S. Lambton, *Continuity and Change in Medieval Persia: Aspects of Administrative, Economic and Social History, 11th–14th Century* (New York, 1988), pp. 258–71.

least on all the reciprocal ties of marriage linking the Chinggisids with their confederates, and the role of the queens' *ordus* (camps/courts) in the dynastic history of the Mongol Empire and the Ilkhanate.³ These studies have benefited in part from advances in other areas of research that provide us with a more complete picture of how the process of state formation may have afforded new opportunities to certain women to exercise a greater role at the apex of the Ilkhanate.

There is, of course, still much more work that needs to be done into the way that Mongol imperialism altered attitudes to gender and marriage. Moreover, there is great potential for collaboration between historians of the east and west of the empire and we eagerly await the co-authored chapter by Broadbridge and Birge in the new *Cambridge History of the Mongol Empire*. Yet there is also a question over whether more could be done to highlight the experience of women outside the Mongol *ordu*. This may pose a problem for historians dealing with a limited range of literary sources and, in the absence of any new material, we should turn towards material evidence in the form of artwork, architecture and the promising work being carried out into the archaeology of mobile pastoralists in Mongolia for further breakthroughs. In any case, studies of marriage practices, property ownership, and ritual have the potential to reveal a great deal more about the broader social and political history of the Mongol Empire.

I

Attempts to explain the relative prominence of Mongol women in relation to their Chinese and Iranian neighbours have typically been grounded in a comparison of the lifeways of the mobile pastoralists and agriculturalists. This type of thinking was advanced especially heavily by anthropologists such as Robin Fox and Jack Goody, who suggest with some justification that there is a correlation between modes of subsistence on the one hand and social and gender hierarchies on the other, with hunter-gatherer and grazing communities evidencing less social stratification or demarcation of private land, which in turn had an effect on the formation of marriage households. In short, they suggest that communities in which men spent greater time away hunting, foraging and fighting showed stronger matrilineal tendencies and afforded women greater control over property and therefore power.⁴ Historians of the Mongol Empire have drawn upon this anthropological literature and supplemented it with textual sources produced by the

3. A. Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire* (Cambridge, 2018); B. De Nicola, *Women in Mongol Iran: The Khātūns, 1206–1335* (Edinburgh, 2017), rev. ante, cxxxv (2020), pp. 459–61.

4. R. Fox, *Kinship and Marriage: An Anthropological Perspective* (Harmondsworth, 1967); J. Goody, *The Oriental, the Ancient and the Primitive: Systems of Marriage and the Family in the Pre-Industrial Societies of Eurasia* (Cambridge, 1990).

Mongol Empire—not least the *Secret History of the Mongols*, the sole surviving history composed by the Mongols themselves—to highlight the critical role played by women in the marriage household and therefore within the later Chinggisid dynasty.

Female property ownership on the Inner Asian steppe was tied to marriage. Daughters were not typically entitled to inherit a portion of their fathers' wealth in the same way as their brothers, who would assume a share of their father's animals and other moveable wealth after marriage, allowing them to establish their own households. Daughters, by contrast, would receive a share of property from their husband, who was expected to provide his bride with a household and a livelihood after marriage. Wealthy Mongols would have up to four wives, each of whom would receive her own tent along with an appropriate number of animals to support them. These wives would then be expected to engage in all aspects of the household economy, including tending to the animals, migrating the camp between seasonal pastures, and even producing clothing, tools and other necessities. Indeed, wives were the virtual managers of their households, a function which they performed with greater autonomy when their husbands were away hunting or fighting. This role was almost certainly exaggerated by the rise of the Mongol Empire, since all able-bodied adult men were liable for military service under the khans.⁵ Moreover, in the event that a husband was killed or predeceased his wife, she would continue to oversee his household. It was, however, equally common for a widow, having assumed responsibility for her husband's property and any young children, to marry a member of her husband's family in a levirate marriage in order to reaffirm her ties to his family and transmit her property to her husband's male relatives, typically younger brothers or sons by another marriage. Women were, therefore, a vital part of the household economy and played an essential role in the transmission of wealth.

The power women enjoyed over their husbands' estates often translated to the imperial household as well. The Persian scholar-bureaucrat, Rashid al-Din Hamadani, provides the example of Nomolun, a powerful Mongol matriarch who assumed control of her husband's people, animals and pastures after his death. In the absence of her son Qaidu, Nomolun presided over a conflict with the Jalayir people, who encroached on the Mongols' pastures after having been pushed north by the Jin. The *Secret History* also speaks of Chinggis Khan's mother, Ho'elun, taking up her husband's banner in order to rally his troops after his murder at the hands of the rival Tatar.⁶

5. B. Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction in Sung and Yüan China, 960–1368* (Cambridge, 2002), p. 2.

6. Rashid al-Din, *Jami' al-tawārikh: Compendium of Chronicles*, tr. W.M. Thackston (3 vols, Cambridge, MA, 1998–9), i, p. 119; *The Secret History of the Mongols: A Mongolian Epic Chronicle of the Thirteenth Century*, tr. I. de Rachewiltz (Leiden, 2004), p. 18.

This kind of stewardship was temporary, only lasting until an adult male could be found to assume control of affairs, yet it could often be prolonged. Following the death of Chinggis Khan's son and heir Ögödei in 1241, the latter's widow Töregene was granted the regency until a new ruler could be chosen. The absence of several princes on campaign in the West, in addition to ongoing uncertainty about the most appropriate candidate and Töregene's reluctance to relinquish the reins of power, meant that this was not achieved until 1246. During this time, Töregene served as the effective ruler of the empire, presiding over the collection of taxes and the minting of coins, as well as managing relations with the subject population. Indeed, it might be argued that her rule was even more consequential than that of her son, Güyük, whose reign lasted less than two years. In short, the role of women in sustaining the household in a nomadic pastoralist economy translated into significant political influence.

Recent scholarship has, however, suggested that we should avoid over-reliance on the anthropological model. Innovative comparative approaches to archaeological research into the mobile pastoralists of Inner Asia have, for example, shown that the traditional juxtaposition of nomads and sedentary farmers has been grossly exaggerated. The neat division between farmers and grazers has been clouded by evidence that testifies to the rather more complex lifeways of early Inner Asians, who typically practiced a mix of mobile pastoralism, hunting, foraging, fishing and even some limited agriculture, in line with similar patterns among mobile pastoralists in sub-Saharan Africa and the Near East. This mixed mode of subsistence produced much more complex social, state and presumably gender groupings, which somewhat undermines the anthropological research mentioned above.⁷ If the Mongols did indeed possess well-defined, if not sophisticated, social and economic hierarchies, then we are obliged to look more closely at other environmental, political and social factors that may have influenced the composition of the Mongol marriage household.

The work of Bettine Birge encourages a more nuanced approach to the study of marriage and property ownership in the Mongol Empire, which highlights how the process of state-formation disrupted and reconfigured traditional relationships. Her analysis of cases contained in the *Yuan dianzhang* provides a rare insight into the lives of common people, which, of course, were markedly different from those of the khan and his senior officials at Daidu (modern Beijing). Indeed, she reveals that there were a number of considerations that informed judicial decisions concerning marriage, the most important being the desire to maintain military households, who were responsible for furnishing

7. W. Honeychurch and C.A. Makarewicz, 'The Archaeology of Pastoral Nomadism', *Annual Review of Anthropology*, xlv (2016), pp. 345–6.

soldiers as well as provisions to maintain the Yuan army.⁸ At first, the Yuan oversaw a dual administration, with the Han Chinese adhering to the earlier Taihe Code of the Jin dynasty, while the Mongols followed their own customs. Yet the Ministry of Revenue, operating under the Central Secretariat, was ultimately given jurisdiction over marriage cases, suggesting that the khan was most concerned with sustaining revenue and corvée duties. This is perhaps best illustrated by a decision from the Ministry of Revenue in 1271 to forbid military households from entering into uxori-local unions, in an attempt to prevent soldiers abandoning the Yuan army.⁹ Marriage was the most common pathway for individuals to change their status—for example switching from the servile class to the commoner class, or from a military household to an entertainment household—and this had the potential to deplete the number of military households on the Yuan register. These rulings were, in some cases enforced brutally. Birge notes that the widows of the ‘New Army soldiers’, who had joined the Yuan after the collapse of the Song dynasty in 1279, were prevented from marrying outside of their divisions, in the hope that they would remarry within their own status-group to produce a new generation of soldiers. When this proved insufficient, captive women from southern China were also required to marry with members of the New Army, reducing them to little more than sex slaves.¹⁰ Mongol attitudes to marriage were, therefore, informed by more than nomadic lifeways. Rather, the Yuan viewed marriage as an essential component underpinning their military strength as well as a means to come to terms with ruling the conquered territory in China. This view only changed, according to Birge, in the fourteenth century, when the oversight of marriage cases passed from the Ministry of Revenue to the Ministry of Rites, where there was a stronger emphasis on ritual purity than taxation.¹¹

Marriage was treated with equal concern at the imperial level because queens were given significant power over the running of the khan’s court. It was customary for the most senior of the khan’s wives to be given their own *ordu*, which they would inhabit and administer throughout their lives. Though the khan typically had multiple consorts, he only had four full wives, of whom only two or three might receive their own *ordus*. These included a large staff with animals, soldiers, servants and slaves numbering in the thousands. Drawing upon the secretarial manual of Muhammad b. Hindushah Nakhjivani, the *Dastūr al-Kātib*, Bayani manages to sketch the basic contours of the royal *ordu*, which she claims was funded through the Persian *diwan* that oversaw revenue collection and the treasury under the Ilkhans. The vizier would, therefore, appoint officials to liaise with the *ordu* to collect revenues and

8. Birge, *Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan*, p. 32.

9. Ibid., p. 184.

10. Ibid., pp. 185–9.

11. Ibid., p. 39.

maintain supplies. Yet there was also an independent staff, including a female overseer, the *ulugh khatun* (great lady), and a commander of the *ordu*, who was charged with overseeing the troops protecting the camp.¹² These *ordus* were central to life at the Ilkhan court, since the khan himself rotated between the residences of his wives, rather than assuming his own separate quarters. Indeed, the presence of the khan situated the khatun's *ordu* at the heart of government. Mongol queens were, therefore, present for all major meetings and decisions, not simply for ceremonial reasons, but as stewards and overseers of the business of government. Not only were they given the chance to provide input on business concerning the state, but their staff were required to co-operate with the khan's officials to ensure the protection of his life, the provision of banquets and correspondence with outside officials. This is explicitly stated by Rashid al-Din, who at one stage describes Chinggis Khan's wife, Börte, co-ordinating with the captains of his bodyguard (*keshig*) to maintain the smooth running of the residence.¹³

Mongol traditions regarding the transmission of property dictated that the khatun's *ordu* would revert back to her husband's family upon her death. The khan would then award the *ordu* to a new wife of his choice. Nevertheless, both De Nicola and Broadbridge demonstrate that these allocations were far from arbitrary and that the bride's family often had a claim to marry another daughter into the *ordu*. Though the sources are often vague, there was a clear tendency among the Ilkhans to award an *ordu* to either a relative or a member of the former bride's household. This could be seen in the case of the *ordu* of Doqуз Khatun, a Kereyid princess who was married to Chinggis's fourth son Tolui before passing to his third son Hülegü in a levirate marriage. Her age and seniority saw her automatically assume the role of Hülegü's senior wife and she appeared regularly alongside her husband in the accounts of Mamluk envoys as well as Armenian and Syriac priests, who sought her patronage as a Nestorian Christian. She died shortly after Hülegü and the new Ilkhan, Abaqa, granted her *ordu* to Tuqtani Khatun, one of his father's former concubines, who also happened to be of the same household (tribe) as Doqуз.¹⁴ Similarly, Ghazan Khan tried to ensure the transmission of the *ordu* of his grandfather's wife, Bulughan Khatun, to members of her tribe.¹⁵ Of course the preservation of an *ordu* in one family or tribe depended upon the availability of suitable brides, many of whom travelled to Iran from Mongolia, but also on the relationship between the khan and the family from which they came.

12. Bayānī, *Zan dar Īrān 'Asr-i Mughūl*, pp. 97–9.

13. Rashīd al-Dīn Hamadānī, *Jāmi' al-Tawārikh*, ed. M. Rawshan and M. Mūsawī (Tehran, 1953), p. 89; Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, p. 21.

14. De Nicola, *Women in Mongol Iran*, p. 156.

15. *Ibid.*

Anne Broadbridge has provided one of the few detailed treatments of the relationship between the khans and these bridal families.¹⁶ Here, too, we appear to be dealing with an imperial, rather than a purely nomadic practice, as we see similar patterns of intermarriage among earlier steppe dynasties, including the Türk Empire (551–744) and the Khitan Liao (915–1125).¹⁷ Within these empires, the ruling dynasty held power with the support of confederate households, who commanded animals, soldiers and pasturelands. The ruler would ensure the loyalty of these aristocratic dynasties by entering into inter-generational marriages with them. This was in part necessitated by the custom, long held in eastern Inner Asia, of marrying outside the agnatic kinship group. Yet the contraction of multiple marriages between the imperial and aristocratic lineages typically had political motives.

The khans initially married into those households which had voluntarily submitted to Chinggis Khan and had thereby retained control of their own troops, such as the Onggirat, Onggut, Ikra and the Oirat. These were distinct from the groups whom the Mongols had subjugated by force, which were liquidated and divided among decimal units commanded by Chinggis Khan and his servants. These divisions appear to have existed well before the unification of the steppe under Chinggis Khan in 1206, and they allow us to divide eastern Inner Asia into atomised and non-atomised communities commanded by *noyans* (commanders) and aristocratic dynasties respectively.¹⁸ Ties between the ruling Chinggisids and these non-atomised units needed to be renewed on a generational basis through an exchange of brides. The Chinggisid sons-in-law were known as *guregen*, whilst their families were given the title *quda*, though both were afforded a special status in the empire. The *guregen* were, for example, included in the councils of notables, summoned to debate and decide upon important matters affecting the empire. Moreover, at least initially, the *guregen* seem to have commanded slightly larger military divisions made up of their own people.

These relationships, contracted for political reasons, challenge the notion that women were entirely separated from their natal household after marriage. Indeed, both De Nicola and Broadbridge list a number of instances in which women drew upon their connections with their natal relatives to enhance their position or that of their children. Perhaps the most famous case concerns Chinggis Khan's wife, Börte, whose brothers and nephew served as commanders in her husband's

16. See also I. Landa, 'Reconsidering the Chinggisids' Sons-in-law: Lessons from the United Empire,' *Chronica*, xviii (2018), pp. 212–25.

17. M. Biran, *The Empire of the Qara Khitai in Eurasian History: Between China and the Islamic World* (Cambridge, 2005), p. 162; J. Skaff, *Sui-Tang China and its Turko-Mongol Neighbors: Culture, Power, and Connections, 580–800* (New York, 2012), pp. 203–6.

18. Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, pp. 102–3.

army.¹⁹ An equally notable example concerns Sorqoqtani Beki of the Kereyid, who married Chinggis Khan's youngest son Tolui. Not only did Sorqoqtani inherit control of her husband's household after his death, but she also appears to have taken advantage of her sister's marriage with Batu Khan, the ruler of the Jochid Ulus, to build an alliance between him and her eldest son Möngke, which resulted in the latter taking the throne in 1251.²⁰ Moreover, the male relatives of Mongol queens enjoyed prominent positions in the Ilkhanate, especially when their Chinggisid son-in-law sat upon the throne.

Control of the khatun's *ordu* seems to have been just as important as any prospective ties with *quda* families. The *ordus* were quite large and there are at least two recorded instances in which the *amir-i ordu* (commander of the *ordu*) is mentioned mobilising troops in support of Ilkhans. Yet, as De Nicola has noted, the ceremonial role of these *ordus* appears to have been equally significant. Serving as the residence of the Hülegüid dynasty from the time before their arrival in Iran, possession of an *ordu* granted the holder some measure of political authority and legitimacy. Control of these *ordus* was one of the pretexts taken for dynastic war between Baidu and Ghazan in 1295. Indeed, De Nicola notes that Ghazan appeared to be waiting eagerly to take his grandfather's widow, Bulughan Khatun, and thus her *ordu*, in a levirate union before assuming the throne.²¹ A temporary truce between Baidu and Ghazan was likewise negotiated in another queen's *ordu*, as was the subsequent trial of the commanders who had supported Baidu in his war with Ghazan.²² The queens' *ordus* were, therefore, important sites of imperial ritual and gatherings. Their transmission had as much to do with the formation of the Mongol Empire as it did with the economic value a wife brought to her family.

II

The study of Mongol women has also provided historians with a useful gauge to measure cross-cultural exchange and interaction between the Mongols and their conquered populations. For the Chinese and Islamic sources of the period, the behaviour, dress and general prominence of Mongol women was a sign of their barbarity. Both Ibn al-Athir and 'Ala al-Din 'Ata Malik Juvayni mention Mongol women leading the massacre of towns and cities in Iran, while the Mamluk author Dawadari almost satirically recorded how Doquz Khatun persistently contradicted Hülegü during a meeting with the Ayyubid ruler of

19. Ibid., p. 68.

20. G. Lane, *Daily Life in the Mongol Empire* (Indianapolis, IN, 2009), p. 239; Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, p. 196.

21. De Nicola, *Women in Mongol Iran*, p. 157.

22. Ibid., pp. 162–3.

Hims in 1260.²³ To outsiders, the liberty with which wives, especially imperial brides, asserted themselves in the business of the court was a complete inversion of the natural order that governed the most basic human relations. Modern historians have analysed the same accounts as a means to measure the extent of Mongol assimilation to the culture of the conquered people.

The conversion of the Ilkhan Ghazan (r. 1295–1304) and his successors to Islam was the most significant concession to the culture of the conquered population in Iran. His Persian panegyrists and bureaucrats seized on the opportunity to portray him as a reviver and renewer of Islamic traditions in order to consolidate his authority inside the Ilkhanate and project his power beyond its borders. Ghazan is therefore described by his vizier, Rashid al-Din, as having reintroduced Islamic law and suppressed the religious pluralism that had prevailed under his predecessors. For women, we are told that the Mongols applied Islamic law to the issues of property inheritance, mandating that women receive a share of their parents' estate (albeit half that of their brothers), while Muslim officials began to encourage Mongol women to observe good Islamic practice, such as veiling.²⁴ Modern historians have suggested that these measures coincided with a decline in the number of influential women mentioned in the sources, though there are a number of notable exceptions.²⁵ Indeed, a cursory survey of the last three decades of Ilkhan history throws up a number of women who dramatically shaped its fate, not least of all Baghdad Khatun, the wife and supposed co-ruler of the last Ilkhan Abu Sa'id (r. 1318–35); his mother Hajji Khatun, who played a role in his elevation to the throne and that of his successor Arpa Ke'un; and Dilshad Khatun, the wife and partner of Hasan Buzurg, the founder of the Jalayirid Sultanate (1342–1413). With this in mind, the books suggest a mixing of Mongol and Islamic tradition, rather than the supplanting of one by the other.

Bruno De Nicola identifies the centralising policies introduced during the reign of Ghazan as the reason behind the decline in women's agency at the Ilkhan court. Only one of Ghazan's wives, Karamu Khatun, is mentioned as being in control of an *ordu*, despite the fact that she produced no sons for him. Moreover, Ghazan tightened his control over the khatuns' revenues, which appears to have curtailed the size of their income. In one instance he is even said to have appropriated control of an *ordu* for himself, declaring it permissible for sons to inherit their mother's property. These measures did not, as De Nicola

23. B. De Nicola, 'Women's Role and Participation in Warfare in the Mongol Empire', in K. Klaus Latzel, S. Satjukow and F. Maubach, eds, *Soldatinnen: Gewalt und Geschlecht im Krieg vom Mittelalter bis Heute* (Paderborn, 2011), p. 101; Abū Bakr ibn al-Dawādārī, *Kanz al-Durar wa Jāmi' al-Ghurar*, VIII, ed. Ulrich Harman (Cairo, 1982), p. 56.

24. Bayānī, *Zan dar Irān 'Asr-i Mughūl*, p. 53; De Nicola, *Women in Mongol Iran*, p. 207.

25. H. Gilli-Elewy, 'On Women, Power, and Politics During the Last Phase of the Ilkhanate', *Arabica*, lix (2012), p. 722; De Nicola, 'Women's Role and Participation in Warfare', p. 109.

observes, see the end of the female *ordus*, but they did diminish the autonomy that women enjoyed at the *ordu*. Whether these measures were part of a broader program of Islamisation is less clear. De Nicola is willing to entertain the idea that the Ilkhan's conversion to Islam did play some role in his decision to curtail the power of the khatuns, yet he finds far more evidence to suggest that the women of the Ilkhanate were simply the victims of a broader campaign to concentrate power in Ghazan's hands.²⁶ Ghazan presided over a purge of both his relatives and his commanders whom he identified as disloyal, causing elite women, along with their families, to suffer a commensurate loss of power. Whether these reforms were effective or simply contingent upon Ghazan's personal style of rule is not explained by De Nicola, but there are clear signs that both the khatuns and their relatives regained much of their lost authority after Ghazan's death in 1304. His brother and successor Öljeitü (r. 1304–16) contracted marriage alliances with a number of the traditional *quda* of the Hülēgüids, including the Oirat and Kereyid.²⁷ Moreover, as we have already noted, both the reign of Abu Sa'id and the events that followed it were heavily affected by the actions of prominent women at the Ilkhan court. This position is supported by recent research carried out by Jonathan (Yoni) Brack into the treatment of Princess El-Qutlugh in the Mamluk sources, which suggests very little change in the behaviour or the status of women in the Ilkhanate after their conversion to Islam.²⁸

Though not engaging directly with the question of Islamisation and acculturation, Broadbridge also proposes alternative explanations for the disruption to the female *ordus* during the reign of Ghazan. Indeed, she points out that Ghazan was never likely to embrace the conventional marriage alliances of his predecessors since his mother was a concubine and he therefore lacked strong ties to the *quda* families.²⁹ Hence, from the beginning of Ghazan's reign, there was an increasing willingness among the Ilkhans to enter into marriages with commanders from atomised lineages, who had begun to entrench themselves at the apex of the Ilkhan state. These atomised lineages, including the Chubanids, Jalayirids, and the Nawruzians, among others, also received Chinggisid brides, whose prestige they drew upon to increase their own power.³⁰ We may also infer that the decline of the khatuns' power (if such a decline every truly took place) was consonant with the overall atrophy of central control in the final decade of Ilkhan rule and that thereafter the focus of the sources shifts to the queens of the Mongolian successor states. In other words, the dislocation suffered during the reign of Ghazan did

26. De Nicola, *Women in Mongol Iran*, pp. 104, 164.

27. Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, pp. 287–8.

28. Y. Brack, 'A Mongol Princess Making *hajj*: The Biography of El Qutlugh Daughter of Abagha Ilkhan (r. 1265–82)', *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, xxi (2011), pp. 331–59.

29. Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, p. 284.

30. *Ibid.*, p. 289.

not apply to all women, nor was there a clear break with earlier Mongol tradition. Rather, the new Muslim Mongol queens continued to act as power-brokers in the late Ilkhanid period and beyond.

The picture from the east of the Mongol Empire is equally complex, with Mongol queens serving as vehicles for the promulgation of new religion and culture, while also preserving their power at the top of the state. Once again, recent scholarship stresses a difference of experience depending upon whether the women in question were drawn from the ruling elite or the conquered population. As some of the wealthiest and most powerful people in Mongol Eurasia, the khatuns were magnets for artists, scholars and missionaries. These interactions allowed the princesses to act as cultural brokers, shaping the rituals, etiquette and patterns of consumption at the Yuan court, while also transmitting new trends to provincial capitals. Examples range from the banquet organised by princess Sengge Ragi, the sister of two qans and the mother-in-law to another, which saw prominent painters and calligraphers exhibit their work in imitation of the Orchard Pavilion Gathering, held in 353 by the calligrapher Wang Xizhi, to Töregene Khatun's order that the governor of Qinzhou should produce copies of the Daoist classics.³¹ Of course, these women also facilitated the spread of Mongolian culture and traditions to the conquered population, as demonstrated by the Mongolian music played by the officials in Khudulugh Khaimish's suite mourning her death in the Koryo court, or the supposed purchase and transmission of a jade heirloom belonging to the family of the famed Mongol commander, Muqali Kuiyang, by princess Kokejin.³² Yet perhaps the best example of Mongol queens acting as purveyors of culture is presented by Qubilai's most senior wife, Chabi Khatun, who is known to have patronised artists, designed uniforms for Mongolian soldiers and, perhaps most significantly, supported Buddhism, donating her jewellery to various monasteries and playing no small part in the rise of Buddhism at her husband's court.³³

Nevertheless, the reunification of China under Yuan rule also coincided with the growing popularity of Neo-Confucianism, which emphasised the authority of the husband and the husband's household in marriage. The Learning of the Way, which stressed a fundamentalist reading of Confucian literature, espoused especially heavily by Chu

31. I. de Rachewiltz, 'Was Töregene Qatun Ögödei's "Sixth Empress?"', *East Asian History*, no. 17/18 (June/Dec. 1999), p. 72; G.Q. Zhao, *Marriage as Political Strategy and Cultural Expression: Mongolian Royal Marriages From World Empire to Yuan Dynasty* (New York, 2008), p. 63; S. McCausland, 'The Art History and Material Culture of the Yuan', in M. Hope and T. May, eds, *The Mongol World* (forthcoming).

32. G.Q. Zhao, 'Control through Conciliation: Royal Marriages between the Mongol Yuan and Koryo (Korea) during the 13th and 14th Centuries', in *Cultural Interactions and Conflict in Central and Inner Asia*, Toronto Studies in Central and Inner Asia, no. 6 (Toronto, ON, 2004), p. 8; Zhao, *Marriage as Political Strategy*, p. 70.

33. M. Rossabi, 'Khubilai Khan and the Women in His Family', in W. Bauer, ed., *Studia Sino-Mongolica: Festschrift für Herbert Franke* (Wiesbaden, 1979), p. 168; Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, p. 239.

Hsi, was becoming increasingly popular among the Chinese scholar-bureaucrats of the thirteenth century, especially those based in the territories of the Southern Song. Chu Hsi's texts and those of his disciples sacralised even the most mundane daily routines, including relations between a husband and a wife. Bettine Birge demonstrates that the disruption provided by the Mongol conquest was all that was needed to allow the Learning of the Way to supplant earlier Chinese legal and moral traditions.³⁴ These views exerted themselves most strongly in the Yuan state through the Central Secretariat and the Ministry of Rites, which by its very nature had a strong Confucian leaning. Yet, in many cases, the teachings of Chu Hsi were most effectively advocated by senior Mongols and Inner Asians in the Yuan bureaucracy, such as the minister Kharghasun and the Qangli Bukhumu, who was educated by a disciple of Chu Hsi.³⁵ These advocates of Neo-Confucianism presided over a new push for widow chastity and reverence for the prescribed mourning period following the death of a husband, which, coupled with a decline in the number of women permitted to keep their dowry, saw an overall decline in women's autonomy under the later Yuan.

Birge shows that the growing influence of Neo-Confucianism, particularly in cases concerning marriage, also saw the decline of some Mongolian marriage practices which had been introduced to China following the Mongol conquest, chief among them being the levirate. From 1304 the Ministry of Rites presided over a return to a dual administrative system in which Mongol and Chinese plaintiffs were treated separately according to their own laws and traditions. Yet from 1330 the levirate was outlawed by the qa'an, allowing Han Chinese women to avoid forced remarriage to their husband's relatives through an appeal to widow chastity.³⁶ These widows received praise from their male descendants, who often commemorated them as heroes in poetic verses, and by the state. Women who committed to widow chastity were, in some cases, given plaques to display outside their homes honouring their virtue and modelling their behaviour for other women. There were even cases in which the Ministry of Rites overruled local Mongol officials, who supported the right of the levir to marry their relative's widows, permitting the women instead to remain chaste and even return to their natal household.³⁷ In each case, the decisions passed down from the Ministry of Rites expounded their duty to uphold the Confucian 'civil traditions' and 'human moral relations'.³⁸

Whether these new Confucian standards of female virtue were applied to the Mongols or simply the Han Chinese remains something

34. Birge, *Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan*, pp. 7–8; Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction*, pp. 2–3.

35. Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction*, p. 253.

36. Birge, *Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan*, pp. 7, 256–7.

37. *Ibid.*, p. 257.

38. *Ibid.*, p. 231.

of an open question. Birge does mention examples of Mongolian women embracing widow chastity after the death of their spouses, but this was often advantageous for the women concerned, since they came from wealthy families and could rely upon them for support. In the case of the aforementioned Sengge Ragi, whose Onggut husband died in 1310, she was awarded the title 'August Virtuous Prosperous Chaste and Long-Lived Supreme Princess' along with 60,000 loads of salt and control of four salt distribution commissions, in addition to a mansion and paper money.³⁹ As the mother in law of Tuq Temür Qa'an, she would have benefited little from remarriage, either with a levir or an outside match. The same could not be said for many poor widows, for whom chastity often equated to poverty. Birge also cites the example of a common Mongol woman by the name of To-to-ni, who similarly turned down a levirate union in order to remain faithful to her husband. Yet she was only able to fulfil this wish by renouncing her claims to her deceased husband's property in favour of his male relatives.⁴⁰ Once again, we see that the experiences of women living under the Yuan varied widely depending upon their social class, ethnicity and financial means.

Birge suggests that the Yuan left an indelible mark on Chinese marriage law. The new hybrid legal system which emerged from the confusion of the Mongol conquest combined the traditional Mongol preference for granting the husband and his family control of his wife and her assets—something which was only reinforced by the androcentric prejudice of the Neo-Confucians, who argued that they were returning to the lost traditions of an earlier, more virtuous past. Shrouded in the veneer of Confucian legitimacy, the Ming and Qing codes outlawed the levirate in all forms, but continued to provide the husband and his family with increasingly greater levels of control over the property of his wife. Widow chastity also remained popular among later dynasties, which abandoned the earlier Song practice of allowing widows to return to their natal homes to care for their parents.⁴¹

Though it is not the focus of their work, Broadbridge and De Nicola likewise indicate the enduring importance of marriage ties to the Chinggisids after the collapse of the Ilkhanate in 1335. Hasan Buzurg, the founder of the Jalayirid Sultanate, proudly espoused his descent from the Chinggisid princess Öljeitei and was regularly referred to as 'Hasan Öljeitei' in the chronicles of the time.⁴² Indeed, the Jalayirids were one of a number of *guregen* dynasties to appear in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries claiming power on the basis of their marriage

39. Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction*, p. 275.

40. Birge, *Marriage and the Law in the Age of Khubilai Khan*, p. 274.

41. Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction*, p. 277.

42. Broadbridge, *Women and the Making of the Mongol Empire*, p. 294.

with Chinggisid princesses, which marked them out as natural heirs to the Chinggisid dispensation. The most prominent of these were the Temürids in Central Inner Asia. Mongol princesses also enjoyed profound influence over the Chubanid, Eretnid and Injuid successor states, suggesting that they continued to enjoy rights to property, which, along with their dynastic pedigree, gave them a strong voice in the affairs of their respective states.

III

Each of the studies discussed in this article has dramatically advanced our knowledge of how the experience of Mongol rule recalibrated attitudes to women in power and marriage households across the empire. Moreover, they further highlight how women shaped the Mongol imperial enterprise. There is incredible potential to apply the methods and approaches adopted in these studies to other parts of the Mongol Empire, while also extending this research into similar geographical, as well as thematic, spaces. Nevertheless, there are significant obstacles to any such work, not least of which are the linguistic barriers that hamper any integrated history of the Mongol Empire and the lack of source material for great swathes of the empire. These obstacles will undoubtedly be traversed more easily as a result of new developments in related fields of Mongolian Studies, which include a better knowledge of the social and political organisation of the Mongol Empire and how it evolved over the course of the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, as well as a willingness to embrace new source material, including material evidence and methods.

Perhaps one of the most glaring gaps in the history of the Mongol Empire concerns the status of Mongolia itself. The shift of the capital from Qaraqorum to Daidu in 1263 resulted in large swathes of western Mongolia in particular being transformed into frontier land. Mongolia retained importance as a symbolic and ritual centre of the empire, but the khan and his court moved south. The women, both elite and common, who remained in this region, though not entirely cut off from the imperial court, therefore remained somewhat more immune to the influence of Tantric Buddhism and Neo-Confucianism. The extent to which the kind of structural and political transformations which have been described here also had an impact on the Yuan homeland remains an open question. 1368 may have marked the end of the Yuan empire in Daidu, but as Munkh-Erdene has mentioned elsewhere, it continued to endure on the steppe; some earlier researchers, such as Jennifer Holmgren and Jack Weatherford, have carried their treatment of marriage and female political power into the Northern Yuan and as late as the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. In her study of the levirate, Holmgren suggests that the Ordos Mongols adopted some of

the Chinese dowry practices, while still retaining the levirate, implying the continuation of the hybrid Yuan model.⁴³ Nevertheless, more work is required to flesh out broader social trends across Mongolia during this period.

Research into women in Mongolia is, however, inhibited by a shortage of literary sources. Without the discovery of new material, fresh methods and tools need to be put to work, the most exciting of which might be archaeological research into the material legacy of the Mongol Empire. Such research is still, to some extent, in its infancy, given the hostility of the previous communist regime, under heavy pressure from the Soviet Union, towards such work. There have, however, been a number of important discoveries in Mongolia since 1991, including the discovery of palatial complexes in the Khentii Region, surveys of the foundations of Qaraqorum, and the identification of large burial and ritual sites throughout the country, each of which has the potential to reveal new information about the lives of common people not mentioned in detail by the court chronicles.⁴⁴

Further research into the women of the Ilkhanate is also limited by the available source material, most of which has long been published in several editions, sometimes in English translation. Here, too, scholars of women in the Mongol Empire have the capacity to benefit from new developments in other related fields. The Ilkhan period lacks the kind of detailed *defters* accounting for legal cases under the Ottoman Empire that might shed light on life beyond the court, but Andrew Peacock has recently produced a highly incisive study on manuscript production and the transmission of knowledge, which can be used to chart broader intellectual, political and social trends in Anatolia.⁴⁵ While such research is unlikely to uncover new information about Mongol women, a study of the voluminous *tafsir* and *hadith* literature produced during the Ilkhanate may potentially open new avenues of research into how shifting intellectual and ideological trends among the *ulema* might have impacted women during this period.

New source material may not, however, always be necessary as there is still a great deal of subject matter which has not been exploited yet. The research of Anne Broadbridge into the *guregen* in particular has filled a long-standing gap in the literature about these important courtiers and the women who empowered them. Moreover, Mongol queens were not the only significant women to appear in the sources. More information is required about Chinggisid princesses, concubines, and wet-nurses, who make regular, though fleeting, appearances in the texts.

43. J. Holmgren, 'Observations on Marriage and Inheritance Practices in Early Mongol and Yuan Society, with Particular Reference to the Levirate', *Journal of Asian History*, xx (1986), p. 169. L. Munkh-Erdene, 'Mongol State Formation and Imperial Transformation: State, Empire, and Political Community', in Hope and May, eds, *Mongol World*.

44. W. Honeychurch, U. Erdenebat and J. Burentogtokh, 'The Archaeology of the Mongol Empire', in Hope and May, eds, *Mongol World*.

45. A.C.S. Peacock, *Islam, Literature and Society in Mongol Anatolia* (Cambridge, 2019).

The role of Mongol queens in the field of diplomacy has even greater potential for expansion in the Ilkhanate, the Yuan and the Jochid Ulus (Golden Horde), for which there are an abundance of sources. Studies into gender and sexuality, as opposed to the study of women, though challenging, are also fields that await treatment. There are, therefore, no shortages of potential new topics that might be covered in future research, we simply need to find the researchers to carry it out. In any case, the published and ongoing work of the historians discussed here have certainly set a pathway that new scholarship is bound to follow.

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